

Your New Nature Is Undefeatable

The Born-Again Trail Clarifies Covenant, Law, and Sonship

In these morning sessions, we have begun exploring what we have affectionately called the born-again trail. We came to the place where we began differentiating between the Old Testament, the old covenant, and what we have called our covenant, which resulted in our sonship and our adoption as sons and daughters of God.

To understand faith, we had to differentiate between those covenants and our sonship. Then we began differentiating between the law, the change of covenants, and the role the law played in it.

The early church, particularly the Galatians, was trying to go back under the law. Paul says, "If you want to go back under the law, then listen to me. I am a Jew. I came out from under the law."

One of the greatest works in the New Testament is the book of Romans. Outside of Jesus, Paul is my favorite teacher. Then John comes next for me. Romans is Paul's masterpiece. I do not know how a man could have known so much unless he was truly an apostle born out of due season and taught by Jesus in His glorified body.

Paul begins Galatians by saying he learned this gospel not of man but by the revelation of Jesus Christ. That matters, because when the church and even early apostles were being influenced back toward the law, Paul came out of due season and said, "I received this directly from the Lord Jesus Christ."

Romans 7 Names the Spiritually Dead Man Under Law

One of the major things God opened to me in Romans was that Romans 7 is truly an unregenerated man under the law. He received the law and could not keep it.

Paul says:

"I had not known sin, but by the law:
for I had not known lust, except the law had said,
Thou shalt not covet."

A spiritually dead man does not know what he is. If you were born with one nature, how would you know anything else until someone came and said, "Stop being what you are"? Then you discover you cannot.

The law became the schoolmaster. It identified sin by commanding the spiritually dead man to do what he had no nature to do.

At the end of Romans 7, Paul cries:

"Who shall deliver me from the body of this death?"

Then he answers:

"I thank God through Jesus Christ our Lord."

Between Romans 7 and Romans 8, the change of covenant takes place into sonship.

No Condemning Sentence Remains for the Man With a New Nature

Romans 8:1 says:

"There is therefore now no condemnation to them which are in Christ Jesus,
who walk not after the flesh, but after the Spirit."

There are no more condemning sentences from the motions of sin which were by the law. Those sentences cannot be carried out in me anymore because I am not spiritually dead anymore.

The phrase "after the flesh" in this context is not talking about a born-again Christian having a bad day in the flesh. It is talking about an unregenerated man under the law who could not keep it. That was their terminology. "When we were in the flesh," Paul says, the motions of sin which were by the law worked death in us.

The change between Romans 7 and 8 is positional truth. I no longer walk after the flesh, meaning I no longer live as a spiritually dead man under law. I walk after the spirit, the new nature I received when I was born again, which set me free from sin.

In Romans 8:1, "Spirit" is not first talking about the Holy Spirit. Paul is stating positional truth. I am no longer spiritually dead. I am spiritually alive.

The Holy Spirit First Bears Witness With What We Became

In Romans 8, the first clear mention of the Holy Spirit comes in verse 16:

"The Spirit itself beareth witness with our spirit,
that we are the children of God."

His Spirit bears witness with my spirit that I am God's child.

The second mention comes in verse 26:

"Likewise the Spirit also helpeth our infirmities:
for we know not what we should pray for as we ought."

Why does Paul say "also"? Because something else has already helped your weaknesses. You were set free from sin when you were born again. That freedom is what the Holy Ghost has to enforce.

The Holy Spirit has nothing to enforce when you stand around justifying sin. If you are born again, you have been freed from it. The devil does not have the power to make you do anything. You may be weak, but you need to start admitting you have victory instead of excusing defeat.

Until you take responsibility for being set free, the Holy Ghost has nothing to work with.

Jesus Was the First Man Qualified for the Spirit Without Measure

Jesus was the first Man to be born spiritually alive since Adam. In Him was life, and that life was the light of men. The same life that was in Him became your light because the same Spirit that quickened Him from death to life now quickened you.

Because your candle has been lit, you can understand God. You are free from sin.

Jesus was also the first Man qualified to receive the baptism of the Holy Spirit without measure. In the Old Testament, because men were spiritually dead, the Holy Spirit could anoint purpose, pursuit, and plan. He could come upon them for miracles and ministry, but He could not move in and live in their regenerated human spirits because they were not yet born again.

Jesus told the apostles:

"He dwelleth with you, and shall be in you."

He also told Peter:

"When thou art converted, strengthen thy brethren."

Jesus was the first Man spiritually alive, and therefore the first Man who could receive the Spirit without measure in His spirit.

The Holy Ghost did not free you from sin apart from the new birth. He performed the work Jesus paid for, but your new nature is what freed you from sin. That is what the Holy Spirit has to work with.

Excuses Trade the Holy Spirit's Power for the Problem's Power

If you say, "I would be further along if it were not for this person," you are giving your excuse more power than your new nature and the Holy Spirit. Heaven does not accept that.

Nobody else can stop your redemption. If another human being could stop you, who could be redeemed?

Being married to the right person may be a benefit, but it is not a necessity for obedience. When you stand before God, no one else will be there for you to blame.

Your first real growth comes when you are honest enough to say, "I am doing what I am doing because I am doing it." You may be too weak to walk in much victory yet, but admit that victory belongs to you. If you begin admitting you have it, one day you will walk in what you are admitting.

If you defend your excuses, the Holy Ghost's work stops inside you because you have traded His power for the power of a problem.

Heaven Works With the Real Person, Not the Performance

I prayed myself into a place in the Holy Ghost where I could not lie. People lie, exaggerate, cover their tracks, and make themselves look better than they are. But heaven operates according to what you really are.

Hypocrisy is one of the things heaven despises most. God answers the prayers of the person you really are, not the person you present yourself to be.

How many times have you colored up the truth so you would not appear as bad as you were? You do not call someone because you did not want to, then say, "I was really busy." Why not just say, "I did not call. I am sorry. I will"?

Those things may seem small, but they reveal where you are operating.

I had to face that even with something as ordinary as my garage. I could give reasons: I had been gone a lot, I had been busy. But when the presence of God came, I finally had to say, "I let it get that way because I let it get that way. I have no excuse except a deficit of character."

When I quit excusing, I began getting free. I care more now about what heaven thinks of me than about maintaining an image before people. Eventually, that way of thinking will make me a testimony in people's sight too.

If the gospel were not preached by people with faults, it would not be preached. But what if it were preached by people sinners could look at and say, "I would like to be like them"?

Peace Is the Great Benefactor of Going From Glory to Glory

As God has opened the law, the born-again experience, and these things I have been through, I have been getting freer and freer.

Peace is a great benefactor of going from glory to glory. It is more to be desired than gold, rubies, and even many things people chase. The fellowship and presence I have with Him are rooted in great peace. It makes life full.

God is love, and the presence of agape is the absence of torment and fear.

Jesus said:

"In the world ye shall have tribulation:
but be of good cheer;
I have overcome the world."

He also said:

"My peace I give unto you."

You may be in this world, but the peace He has where He is, He gives to you so you can live in that peace here.

When turmoil, hatred, strife, unforgiveness, and fear get inside, they are hard on the body. If I did not have peace, I would walk the floor and call Jesus my peace until peace permeated me from the inside out. Jesus becomes to you what you call Him.

Victory Begins by Accepting That Sin Lost Dominion

The first mention of the Holy Spirit in Romans 8 is His Spirit bearing witness with mine. The second is that He also helps my weaknesses. What helped first? The fact that I was made free from sin in my new nature.

That freedom is what the Holy Ghost uses to execute victory.

When I acknowledge that the devil, the flesh, and every friend of sin does not have the power to defeat me, peace begins. I have been made free from the law of sin and death.

It may look terrible right now, but I will win because I have already won. I am giving the Holy Ghost what He needs to execute my victory. Peace reports to me that I may as well feel like I am on the other side already, because the result is settled.

From glory to glory, He is changing me.

Antioch Shows How Judaism Pressured the Gentile Church

I have been trying to get to God's covenant with Abraham for sonship. Later, because of transgression, the law was added to that covenant. So we have been differentiating between law and grace, and the teacher in me knows we need to keep exhorting until understanding rises enough to continue.

At Antioch, some came from James in Jerusalem. From Antioch, the same influence moved on to Galatia. These teachers were not denying that Gentiles were being saved or becoming heirs as Abraham's seed. They were saying Paul was a good teacher, but he did not understand that

Gentiles had to go on and keep the law to be perfected.

Paul writes to a Galatian church made up of both Gentiles and Jews. Since they were being pulled back under the law, Paul speaks as someone who came out from under it.

Galatians 2:11 says:

"But when Peter was come to Antioch,
I withstood him to the face,
because he was to be blamed."

Paul stood up to one of the original apostles. Peter was not perfect, and thank God for grace.

Peter's Hypocrisy Was Returning to Kosher Separation

Galatians 2:12-13 says:

"For before that certain came from James,
he did eat with the Gentiles:
but when they were come,
he withdrew and separated himself,
fearing them which were of the circumcision.
And the other Jews dissembled likewise with him;
insomuch that Barnabas also was carried away with their dissimulation."

The word "dissimulation" means hypocrisy.

I used to picture this as a banquet where Jews and Gentiles were all eating together, then men from James walked in and the Jews suddenly moved to the other side of the room. But that is not what Paul is talking about.

This was about kosher food. Peter had already been shown in Joppa, through the sheet full of unclean animals, that God had cleansed the Gentiles. God said, "What I have cleansed, do not call common or unclean."

So Peter had been eating what Gentiles ate. When the Judaizers came, he separated himself and went back toward the law. Then others followed, even Barnabas.

Rebuilding the Law Says Christ's Blood Was Not Enough

Galatians 2:14-18 says:

"But when I saw that they walked not uprightly according to the truth of the gospel,
I said unto Peter before them all,
If thou, being a Jew, livest after the manner of Gentiles,
and not as do the Jews,
why compellest thou the Gentiles to live as do the Jews?
We who are Jews by nature,
and not sinners of the Gentiles,
Knowing that a man is not justified by the works of the law,
but by the faith of Jesus Christ...
For if I build again the things which I destroyed,
I make myself a transgressor."

Paul's argument is this: Peter, if you are a Jew and you were living after the manner of Gentiles because the blood of Jesus saved you apart from keeping the law, why are you now compelling Gentiles to live as Jews?

If you rebuild the law after receiving Christ, you are saying the blood of Jesus was not enough. You make Christ a minister of sin because you are saying His blood left you in transgression unless you return to the law.

That is why Paul withstood Peter.

Sabbath and Jubilee Were Shadows of Rest Already Entered

Many believers who live around Jewish practice keep some facet of the law, often the Sabbath or feast days. But the Sabbath was a type of the rest we entered when we were born again. We ceased from the burden and labor of our own sin.

That is why Sabbath work was forbidden under the law. It was a type showing that salvation would not come by your works, lest any man should boast. It is the gift of God.

If I rebuild what Christ destroyed, I make myself a transgressor.

The same is true of Jubilee. If you are waiting for some supernatural freedom to come because you are acknowledging a fiftieth-year celebration, you will wait a long time. You cannot be set freer than you were set two thousand years ago.

Jubilee was a type of Jesus dying, setting captives free, and bringing us into the acceptable year of the Lord. Two minutes after Jesus said, "It is finished," every freedom available under sonship was available to the saints.

There may be prophetic time clocks among nations as history moves toward the end, but none of that limits the son of God who has entered rest. You are free until the end of time. Enjoy it.

Joint Heirs Receive the Oldest Brother's Full Inheritance

Under Jewish law, the oldest brother received the inheritance of the father. Jesus is your oldest Brother in the family of God. He received full inheritance, then turned around and made you a joint heir.

You are not the second brother receiving second place. You are a joint heir with the Firstborn.

Do not rebuild what He destroyed. You are not limited by a calendar. You have inherited with Christ.

Through the Law Christ Freed Those Under the Law

Galatians 2:19 says:

"For I through the law am dead to the law,
that I might live unto God."

Galatians 3:12-13 explains:

"The law is not of faith:
but, The man that doeth them shall live in them.
Christ hath redeemed us from the curse of the law,
being made a curse for us:
for it is written,
Cursed is every one that hangeth on a tree."

Christ was born under the law and was obligated to fulfill the law. Because He fulfilled it, He could free those who were under it.

Galatians 4 says:

"God sent forth his Son,
made of a woman,
made under the law,
to redeem them that were under the law,
that we might receive the adoption of sons."

I, through the law, am free from the law because the One who freed me was born under the law and fulfilled it for those who could not.

The Rebellious Son Text Points to Christ Bearing the Curse

Deuteronomy 21:18-23 says that if a man had a stubborn and rebellious son who would not obey his father or mother, the parents brought him to the elders, and he was stoned. Then the passage says:

"If a man have committed a sin worthy of death,
and he be to be put to death,
and thou hang him on a tree:
His body shall not remain all night upon the tree...
for he that is hanged is accursed of God."

All of that is one thought.

The stubborn and rebellious son was a type of those under the law who could not keep it. God said, "Thou shalt not covet" and "Thou shalt not bear false witness," but they were spiritually dead and could not help but fail. Under the law, they were guilty.

Jesus fulfilled the law, then stepped into the shoes of every rebellious son who could not keep it. He took the penalty, was hung on a tree, and became the curse of the law. He died in their place so that those under the law could go free and receive adoption as sons.